

Infrastructure Aesthetics

Concepts for the Study of Culture



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Infrastructure Aesthetics

Edited by
Solveig Daugaard, Cecilie Ullerup Schmidt
and Frederik Tygstrup

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Solveig Daugaard, Cecilie Ullerup Schmidt and Frederik Tygstrup

Introduction: Surfacing Infrastructures in the Arts

All artistic work, like all human activity, involves the joint activity of a number, often a large number, of people. Through their cooperation, the artwork we eventually see or hear comes to be and continues to be.

Howard Becker, *Art Worlds*, 1982.

Infrastructural art

Across the various “art worlds” where contemporary art, performance, and literature are being produced and consumed, the borders between the artwork and its surroundings are becoming increasingly blurred. At the 2022 documenta fifteen in Kassel, the artist collective ruangrupa curated and filled the exhibition spaces with collective practices: artists’ studios migrated into the exhibition room, kitchens, gardens, and self-organized schools became gathering spaces, printing zines took center stage, and visa applications for artists traveling from the Global South to Germany became some of the main artistic practices. documenta fifteen provincialized the disinterested aesthetic experience of the art object and displayed how the artist collectives were reorganizing, moving, and living in the Eurocentric exhibition space and its inherited colonial and extractive aesthetics. In 2019, when the visual artist Eliyah Mesayer obtained her Danish citizenship and diploma from the art academy, on the exact same day she decided to start the Mesayer Foundation which offers grants for citizenship applications to stateless young people. By demanding gallerists to pay forty percent of their earnings from selling her work to the foundation, she nudges actors who possess economic agency in the art world to contribute to an accumulation of infrastructural support for stateless subjects. In 2021, Anonymous Artists submerged a plaster copy of a bust of Frederik V, founder of The Royal Academy of Arts, into the Copenhagen harbor; they staged this ritualist execution against the backdrop of the colonial debts of the king and his Academy, desiring “to call attention to the art institutions whose foundations exist and were made possible by this colonial era” (Anonymous Artists 2021); and so surfaced a submerged controversy about racism and representational politics in Danish art and art education. In 2012, the feminist-activist performance art collective Pussy Riot staged a musical “Punk Prayer” inside the Russian Orthodox Cathedral of Christ-the-Savior wearing brightly col-

ored balaclavas and mocking president Putin to out the latent alliance between church and state. They deliberately choreographed the routine of the religious and police authorities who intervened on the spot, as did the Moscow city bureaucracy and court of law. The latter handled the intervention's legal aftermath, thus getting the authorities to participate in an immersive performance where their predictable misogynist authoritarianism and desperate control freakery was on display as was their brutal, ridiculous, and profoundly theatrical behavior. In his self-titled poetry collection from 2013, Danish-Palestinian poet Yahya Hassan pre-empted and comments on his own future reception as a celebrated and controversial minoritized poet. Hassan's 2019 follow-up collection not only exhibits and condemns the inherent violence in this reception but also performatively delegitimizes its readers' inevitable participation in it. The 2021 winner of the Goncourt literary prize in France, Mohammed Saar Mgoubar's *La plus secrète mémoire des hommes*, fictionally retraces its own coming into being in the historical and contemporary interactions between Senegalese and French literary culture and makes the racial conditions of its own production the core of the narrative.

What art practices like these have in common is that the artwork overflows its borders by bleeding into the social, political, and institutional frameworks around it and at the same time enveloping these frameworks in what is being exhibited. What is on display in such instances is not a delimited artwork that *appears* in an institutional and social setting; rather, the display now *includes*, *intervenes into*, or even *repurposes* the setting, as part of the work. To understand this interplay, we suggest examining the relation between the artworks and the frameworks that afford them as an *infrastructural* relation. This relation, we contend, becomes increasingly important as still more artworks no longer just work in an infrastructural setting but work *with* infrastructure.

Art worlds are replete with and crucially dependent on infrastructures. There are institutions for art making and institutions that provide knowledge of art and of how to appreciate art; there are historically specific modes of production of art with a variegated set of social, material, and economic conditions and affordances; there are notions of quality and professionalism based on educational recognition, genre codes, and clarity of form which are giving access to the institutions and financial subsidies; there are platforms for publication, exhibition, performance, and so on; there are market places and ramified circulation systems; and there are discursive agencies ranging from reviews to research; there are institutions for archiving, maintaining and ordering, and there are the venues and the protocols that frame the social forms and interactions that exist around art. All such institutional, material, and social forms, borders, and processes need to be in place as something everyday and humdrum to make that which we call "art" possible. These infrastructural conditions that underlie the production and facilitate the consumption

of art are normally taken for granted and, like most infrastructures that work in the background in a quasi-invisible way, underestimated.

The contemporary artworks mentioned above perform what feminist sociologist of information Susan Leigh Star has called “infrastructural inversion.” They make the infrastructural work visible by demonstrating what goes on *behind* the different scenes to make art appear *on* these scenes as authored and accredited artworks – provided to individual contemplation by institutions of distribution and consecration. Against this backdrop, we suggest considering artistic practices that transgress the traditional functional use of the art circuit as *infrastructural art*, because it bleeds into the infrastructures of production and distribution, and because it makes these infrastructures into integral parts of the artistic expression, not only as a support structure for art, but as part and parcel of what art is and how it exists in society. When artistic practices not only appear in social and material infrastructures but use infrastructural conditions as their artistic medium, then analyzing such practices can proffer insight into contemporary art, performance, and literature that isolated studies of the (autonomous) artworks themselves, the production conditions of artists and art workers, or reception and audience studies, are not able to provide. While all these infrastructural conditions are currently being made visible and become the material of the artworks themselves, we are in a historical situation where they intersect in new ways with other infrastructures – many of them digital, some of them gendered, classed, or colonial – not specific to the art world but serving increasingly vital functions in the production, circulation, and presentation of art.

Colleagues in the field of arts and cultural studies have for the past few years been probing the notion of infrastructure to describe the drawing of borders, flows, and circulations in both artistic and epistemological frameworks. Scholars such as cultural theorist Lauren Berlant and performance theorist Bojana Kunst have used the term to describe the patterns and backgrounds of cultural production and the interests they mediate (Berlant 2016; 2022; Kunst 2023). Feminist political theorist and critic Marina Vishmidt stresses how infrastructures are specific and biopolitical sources for social reproduction, strategically founded on “no-infrastructures for some insofar as it supports accumulation for others” (Vishmidt 2022, 35). Infrastructures look like simple structures for use but are highly political. Thus, the term *infrastructure aesthetics* locates and instigates action in conflicts of who distributes what to whom – and who withholds something from others. Neighboring concepts to “infrastructure” currently circulating in the traditions of Black radical thought and Black feminist theory are capitalist “logistics” suggested by Stefano Harney and Fred Moten and colonial onto-epistemological infrastructures described and analyzed by Denise Ferreira da Silva (Harney and Moten 2021; Ferreira da Silva 2022).

Vishmidt stresses that the critique of infrastructure in art worlds is a deepening as well as a transgression of the tradition of institutional critique, moving from seeing and reflecting upon the agential (what the institution does right or wrong) to analyzing and *changing* its transversal embeddedness in greater material and epistemological racialized, classed, and gendered conditions. And where institutional critique, in Vishmidt's account, sticks with the institution as its ultimate horizon, its infrastructural radicalization "takes the institution as a historical and contingent nexus amenable to re-arrangement through struggle and different forms of inhabitation and re-distribution" (Vishmidt 2022, 30). It is a critique that implies action: "a critique that cuts and lets in air, a critique that takes upon itself to find or make the holes through which this infrastructure comes into view" (Vishmidt 2022, 32).

Thus, with infrastructure aesthetics, a fundamental change – we do not call it a *turn* – can be observed in the tradition of aesthetic theory. Art historian and curator Nora Sternfeld suggests a paradigmatic shift from art as representation to art as "the collective creation of infrastructures," meaning that art has become a site of imagining and crafting other futures collectively (Sternfeld 2023).¹

With this book, we aim to present an infrastructure aesthetics that can address the *analytical* problem of how to work with disseminated and contextually ingrained artworks, the *aesthetic* problem of how to assess artistic forms that operate on an infrastructural level, and the *political* problem of how to understand artistic agency in the sphere of the social beyond what can be recorded as pertaining to the content or "message" dimension of the autonomous artwork.

Infrastructure studies

Over the last decades, infrastructure studies have gained momentum across the humanities and social sciences. Inspired by different trends in cultural geography, history of technology, structural anthropology, media history, and information studies, infrastructural analysis has come to designate a trans-disciplinary and intersectional interest in the *organization of social processes* and the *systemic relations* that is afford to them. Thus, geographers (e.g., Thrift 2007) and anthropologists (e.g., Bowker and Star 2000) have emphasized how the material infrastructure – roads and tracks,

¹ While Sternfeld introduces this change from representation to infrastructure aesthetics in her lecture on learning from documenta fifteen in April 2023, she definitely draws on the thinking about infrastructures developed collectively since 2011 with the freethought collective (Irit Rogoff, Stefano Harney, Adrian Heathfield, Massimiliano Mollona, Louis Moreno, and Nora Sternfeld).

wires and pipes – is not just a set of semi-invisible utilities, only to be remarked upon when they fail, but an active instrument in the social organization of a society. They are structures of relation and distribution, but they are also *structuring* devices that format material processes and thus, as Brian Larkin has it, a “techno-politics” (Larkin 2013, 328). In parallel, since the late 1990s, the different “techno-aesthetics” (Simondon 2012) of specific media infrastructures have been explored and cultivated by experimental and tinkering practices of network-based media art and artistic research (Emerson et al. 2021) closely informing studies of media archeology, collaborative media design, and global information architecture. These practices have effectuated a conceptual shift of focus and attention from *media aesthetics* to *infrastructure aesthetics* (Gansing 2023) and rearticulated the pivotal aesthetic dimension of infrastructure as a structuring device in (digital) art and culture. Meanwhile the infiltration of information systems by computational technology has boosted the logistical conception of infrastructure. While there was always an infrastructural aspect to systems for categorization, classification, and calculation (Bowker and Star 2000), with the “age of planetary computerization” (Guattari 2013) such processes are becoming wired, traceable, and actively involved in thinking as sense-making and decision-making in more tangible ways. Digital infrastructure such as search engines, databases, data-driven algorithms, and digital archives which organize enormous bodies of knowledge increase the entanglement between infrastructures that come across as “material” and as “immaterial” and introduce new velocities and patterns into the structuring of (im)material processes. Connections are configured through tracing and tagging; values and preferences are imposed through rankings and ratings; attention is regulated through recommendations; access to information, capital, and goods is administered through algorithmic calculations, computational protocols, and machine learning. In this way “thinking infrastructures fold into themselves an archaeology of concepts, tasks and processes that make thought and thinking possible” (Kornberger et al. 2019) and generate a series of material consequences that remain unevenly distributed on a global scale (Ritasdatter 2020).

Seeing infrastructures as forms that create processes of exchange and transformation has in turn invited to examine practices of government, in Foucault’s understanding of the term (Foucault 2004), as infrastructures, as blueprints of *social* exchange and transformation, inscribed in jurisdictions, bureaucracies, and institutional forms to create an infrastructure of “socio-technique” (Mattern 2015, 95). The same infrastructural functions have been recognized in the more ephemeral spheres of culture and everyday life, where social *habitus* (Bourdieu 1979) and culturally specific schemata of cognition and affect (Descola 2005) are recognized as structuring devices as well, not visible as hardware infrastructures, but effective nonetheless and inferable to deep-seated structures in cultural forms of life.

Infrastructural studies, in this sense, amounts to highlighting infrastructural processing as a “structuring structure” with a serious social and political import, and in addition, to expand this understanding to our analysis of institutional and cultural forms and consider, for instance, bureaucratic structures (Graeber 2015) or structures of feeling (Williams 1977) as “soft infrastructures” alongside their “hard” counterparts (Peters 2015). These two moves, *exposing* infrastructure and *expanding* the scope of infrastructure studies, in turn permits two other features of infrastructural analysis to surface. Firstly, that the different levels of infrastructural organization are *interrelated*, as, for instance, when algorithmic infrastructures leverage affective infrastructures (Ahmed 2010) or plumbing becomes an integral part of military agency (Weizman 2007); in both cases, the concatenation of different infrastructural levels becomes a means of world-making (Larkin 2013) and contributes to outline the spatio-temporal framing of social existence (Tygstrup 2017). And secondly, that infrastructures are *productive* as they organize relations and flows, not just supporting material and social functions, but actually “patterning social form” (Berlant 2016, 393) by way of creating dispositions, switches, and relays through which social and material processes are instantiated and formatted (Easterling 2014).

If, as architect Rem Koolhaas quipped, “infrastructure is more important than architecture” (Shackle 2012), this momentum invites us to pay closer attention to well-known (albeit often understudied) infrastructures (Star 1999) and moreover, to consider the infrastructural function of any kind of mediated exchange “binding people and things into complex heterogeneous systems” (Larkin 2013, 335). In the first instance, the infrastructural approach prompts a shift of focus from the subjects and objects that populate the world toward the relations that exist between them; and from the structure of such relations toward the fluxes and processes they afford. And in the second instance, in the “expanded” understanding of infrastructure, a similar shift is taking us from seeing people and things as situated in a context to seeing them as taking part in this context, as parts of an assemblage or ecology; and, finally, to understand the phenomena we study not as isolated, circumscribed beings, but beings that develop and change through their modes of existence.

Exposing the functions of the infrastructural and expanding the range of infrastructural analysis cannot avoid blurring the otherwise self-explanatory notion of infrastructure; from conditions of possibility for a fungible material organization of the world to a network of effective relations that are underpinned by material as well as immaterial scaffoldings and protocols. This entails that studies of infrastructure are no longer resting on a solid definition of a *research object*, but instead rests on a particular *research approach*, namely, to see processes of recurrent relational interaction as societal infrastructures. Infrastructural analysis hinges not on what we study, but on how we study it.

Infrastructure aesthetics

Against the backdrop of the recent upsurge in interdisciplinary infrastructure studies, we claim that infrastructure aesthetics can provide an innovative approach to studies in contemporary art and literature. We propose to do this by analyzing the increased occurrence of infrastructural art, and by developing a conceptual framework for an infrastructure aesthetics that can provide more adequate tools for understanding and discussing the contemporary art scene. Ultimately, the goal is to contribute to the conceptualization and analysis of the changing role and function of art in society and the new interfaces that emerge between artistic expressions and the social context in which they appear. What is at stake, in other words, is an attempt to gauge the societal mode of existence of art in the historical present.

In recent years, the immersion of art into a digital media ecology constituting a pervasive interdiscursive field, where no “outside of the media” exists (Zielinski 2013) and the abundance of mixed media practices across the arts has fed a discussion about a “post-medium condition” in the arts, demanding a transgression of the conceptual framework of a modernist aesthetic of medium specificity with its reliance on positivist purism and separability (Krauss 2000) and calling for a material and socio-political “post-media transition” countering the “hegemony of mass media powers” (Guattari 2009, 299). Whereas the discourse around some art forms, i.e. literature, is often accused of “lagging behind visual arts” when it comes to questions of (inter)mediality (Gysin 1978; Gilbert 2022, 10) with its institutions refraining from recognizing *as literature* practices challenging a print culture-based medium specificity (Dworkin 2011), the visual art circuit and its institutions has proved remarkably agile in usurping the abounding “mixed media” practices into a smooth-running commercial framework effectively indifferent to the specificities of different material practices (Krauss 2000). In this light, the prevalence of practices immediately conceptualized as “visual art” in the examples taken up in the chapters of this book, might suggest that similar circumstances persist for infrastructural art practices. However, infrastructure aesthetics both expands and exceeds such discussions. Infrastructural practice abounds in all the arts, but the way it is articulated differs significantly in the different art forms and different material practices due to the techno-aesthetic implications of each of them, in accordance with the heightened attention to the “differential specificity” of specific media (Krauss 2000) and with aspirations of altering apparently fixed relations of power via engagement with the materiality of media infrastructure (Guattari 2014; Daugaard 2018a). This, in turn, expands the range – materially, institutionally, politically – of the infrastructural interventions performed by such practices.

The vocabulary of infrastructure studies invites us to describe “art” not as a coherent series of objects, not as adherence to a finite set of rules (not even the default rule that there is no rule), not as dependent on any individual act of judgment, but as precisely an infrastructural process of coordinating and aligning a living circulation between these ontologically quite different parts in the chain that reproduces art as a social fact. Infrastructure aesthetics looks at art as a social sphere of practices framed by historical institutions, cultural expectations, and social relations, and a corollary variety of modes of production and consumption of art. Rather than focusing on art objects, we need to appraise their mode of existence upstream toward the conditions of their production, and downstream toward the conditions of their consumption. This is not a matter of situating art in some larger context, it is about pinpointing the precise set of relations, mediations, and distributions that contribute to reproduce our expectation that something like art exists. Infrastructure aesthetics situates the object of study through a different grammar than the one cherished by Western rationality that examines the relations that exist between objects; it instead examines the web of relations that make it possible to imagine something like a world of discrete objects. Hence, to adequately describe and better understand the social life of art and the role and function of art in the bigger framework of social and cultural reality, infrastructure aesthetics systematically aims to include the different strands of production, expression, and reception of art in a historical description of the social mode of existence of art.

In the modern, “aesthetic” regime of art, as theorized by philosopher Jacques Rancière, the artwork is an object that retains its qualities only when it is *considered* to be an artwork, that is, in philosophical parlance, a noetic rather than a noematic object. The art object becomes an art object by being looked at with a particular set of expectations that are prerequisite to make its qualities as precisely a work of art come forth. The qualities are in the eye of the beholder, so to speak, as per the definition of the reflective judgment of taste famously expounded by Kant. But the beholder, on the other hand, does not possess the sovereignty to make this assessment; the methodological individualism often associated with the Kantian sovereign and disinterested individual judgment is overwritten and scaffolded by a set of validating infrastructural acts surrounding the object and prepping it for being considered in this way. Academies, museums, concert halls, editors, discourses, universities, and so forth. The ineffable “something” that makes art into art is not an intrinsic quality, but it is also not a matter of the mere individual pleasure taken in encountering something beautiful; it resides neither in the object, nor in the subjective judgment, but becomes, in the historical process of establishing an institutional framework around the “art world,” an infrastructurally defined quality. The quarrel about whether aesthetic quality resides in the object

or in the beholding subject will eventually demise in the light of an infrastructure aesthetics.

Though instigated by contemporary conditions for art, the delineation of an infrastructure aesthetics has important offshoots for cultural phenomena, both historical and in the present, that are not habitually conceptualized as artistic practices. When an infrastructure aesthetics is applied, other objects are surfacing, and other processes are becoming important; as we become aware of criteria of selection that have been so pervasive that they have escaped direct scrutiny, we are able to question what is brought to our attention as art, and how this categorization affects these objects of our attention.

What consequences do this infrastructural research agenda have for academic studies of arts and culture? At least three methodological transitions are at stake, when infrastructures inform the cultural analysis. Firstly, the analytical interest moves from object to *relatedness*: instead of looking only at the aesthetic object, we can look at the object in relation to the conditions and practices of its production, and in relation to the interactions and exchanges in its reception (Glissant 1990). Or, as Ariella Azoulay has suggested, we cannot look at the photography alone, but at photography in its inseparable relation to its social and material history, and the ethico-political situation in which it is produced and which it coproduces (Azoulay 2008). The same transition is articulated by media theorist Bernhard Siegert, in his theorization of fundamental “cultural techniques” such as alphabetic writing, calendars, and grids for measuring space, that become “anthropotechnics” that co-constitute personhood, time, and space (Siegert 2015). Secondly, the analytical interest moves away from an idea of context as something surrounding a delineated object of interest to the ideas of assemblage (Deleuze and Guattari 2002) and ecology (Guattari 2014; Fuller 2005; Hörl 2017): that the cultural relation is always-already a part of a larger body of influences, mediations, interests. This implies that the making and meaning of the cultural relation is distributed across a transmedial field where established hierarchies between figure and ground no longer hold, and where objects, as Lauren Berlant has it, “are always looser than they appear” (Berlant 2022, 25). This distribution of agency can be witnessed, for instance, in the way the literary circuit functions in a post-digital context where the printed book is one among many articulations of a literary work across multiple platforms. Here, the production of literary meaning is distributed in both time and space, as writers’ relations and communities, editorial interventions, publishers’ promotion material, print, e- and audiobooks, social media profiles of writers and readers, journalistic content, and critical reception all participate in a complex feedback loop that generates the “object” commonly experienced as the literary work. Thirdly, our analytical awareness of infrastructures now caters for a sensibility toward *temporalities* – that shaping is taking place over time and

across institutions, networks, policies, and platforms. Our focus on temporalities in the plural is shaped by Rob Nixon's concept of "slow violence" (Nixon 2011) and by media theorist Sarah Sharma's notion of "chronopolitics" (Sharma 2014) – that temporal inequality and temporalities of slowness and speed are manifestations of power – and that the ideas of temporal separability, sequentiality, and exception (the isolation in a moment, a certain, limited time span) sustain a European, modern construction of linear temporality and productivity (Harney and Moten 2021, 28; Ferreira da Silva 2017, 83). Instead, we suggest observing parallel and controlled as well as uncoordinated temporal flows upstream and downstream, both synchronically and diachronically, both in progression and regression. A sensibility toward temporalities requires a de-isolation of the analytical object: to read it processually across production, presentation, and reception, and looping back into the production of other, neighboring non-artistic objects. Think of how racism is a performative configuration that conflates public uprisings, online debates, everyday interpellations, political silencing or representation, institutional discrimination, or diversity policies over time. Think of how workflows of the artist-worker syncopate between intensities of deadlines and periods of waiting, between being understood as relevant to society and as being useless. Think of how the object of art is being understood as an object and as a "social structure" from one time to another, and of who takes an interest in these shapings and in which media and disciplines, and for how long the hype goes on, or how quickly it ends.

Across the entire spectrum of artistic genres and media, the contemporary art scene is replete with art practices that appear boundless, medially mixed, and difficult to separate from their surroundings to a degree where they can no longer be meaningfully aligned with conventional histories of art and literature where periods and styles are perceived as responding to and replacing each other in linear succession (Rebentisch 2020). If current practices of infrastructural art actively question the interpellation of the contemporary artist to perform as an individual as it is amplified by the infrastructures of support, distribution, and reception of the art world (Daugaard et al. 2020), then cultural analysis informed by infrastructure aesthetics must question fundamental mechanisms of art history's individualizing principles of organization and provide new entry points for the analysis of aesthetic phenomena. Informed by contemporary critiques of authorial isolation this could include a critical revisiting of the influential author-title-principle, a cultural technique associated with the world's first library catalog, the *Pinakes*, which was produced at the library of Alexandria and preconditions the notion of an "author-function" as formulated by Michel Foucault (Foucault 1998). Or, an infrastructural analysis, formed and informed by our historical present of continued coloniality, mediation, and uncontrollable interaction, can contribute to understand the modes

of existence in the arts in other historical periods. As an example, the archeologist and art historian Amalie Skovmøller has analyzed the commissioning interests and geographical and human relations of transportation behind the white marble monumental sculptures of the Danish colonial era. What does it imply, not to look at the portrayed figure of the sculpture, the portraying technique, or the artistic expression of it, but rather to attend to the network of circulated material, economic and enslaved support “underneath” or “behind” such sculptures, supported by the aesthetic ideas of purity and whiteness in the period of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries? And what happens if this approach is extended into contemporary debates about colonial or confederate monuments; what if rather than letting our attention be caught by the despicable historical figures that are portrayed, we look to the economic and “cultural infrastructures” that keep such monuments in place while reproducing the inequities they incarnate – only in the present (Hass 2022)? If infrastructural art practices can appear difficult to address via the established distinctions of aesthetic theory, they can, however, provide us with explanatory insights into modes of entangled existence of art in our historical present (Glissant 1990; Latour 2012; Dirckinck-Holmfeld 2022). And moreover, a crucial component in the development of an infrastructural aesthetics will consist in revisiting the constitution of the object of aesthetics in the light of the insights proffered by contemporary infrastructural art.

Politics of infrastructure

The “technopolitical” aspect of infrastructure (Larkin 2013) is highly relevant for infrastructure aesthetics. Focusing on infrastructure when dealing with art (and not on form, or intention, or judgment) makes us aware of how artistic agency is politically *framed* by way of its infrastructural conditioning, and of how artistic agency is likewise politically *active* in the ways in which it exposes infrastructural mechanisms of framing, puts extant infrastructures to use in novel ways, or eventually intervenes in other social infrastructures.

The political *framing* has to do with the infrastructural affordances of art, the tightly knitted system of institutions, procedures, discourses, techniques, and materials that ensure that artworks can be produced, circulated, used, and recognized as such. All these partial and interrelated pieces of affordance (and many more could be itemized, different for the individual forms and genres of art production, but all displaying a similar functional nexus of selecting, differentiating, and privileging) have a clearly visible political function. This attention to the ways in which infrastructural affordances actively (albeit not always very visibly)

encourage and privilege some procedures, circuits, and formats over others, providing a regime that reproduces well-established forms and habits and occults alternative ways of working, continues the tenor of the institutional critique of the 2000s and 2010s. However, as conducted in relation to infrastructural aesthetics, it observes a deeper and transversal implicatedness that goes beyond the institutional and its historical present (Vishmidt 2022; Ferreira da Silva 2022). The infrastructural perspective invites us to understand institutional mechanisms in a broader and more systematic (and scholarly, more demanding, and possibly transdisciplinary) way; it also helps us detect less immediately visible mechanisms of political differentiation and distribution in the infrastructural processes of the art world. The insight into the mechanisms of framing – and the politics of framing – that follows from infrastructural analysis, concomitantly invites us to re-describe cultural policy as a care for cultural infrastructures and invites us to formulate criteria of infrastructural “quality” (including accommodating challenges pertaining to diversity, equity, inclusion, access, anti-coloniality). This analytical and critical perspective on infrastructure draws on the recent upsurge in Black feminist theory and anti-colonial studies and the analytical approaches and tools developed to unveil mechanisms of bias, othering, and unjust distribution of agency and recognition that are reproduced through deep-seated structures and processes that need to be foregrounded, in the work of, e.g., Franz Fanon, Bojana Kunst, Stefano Harney, Fred Moten, and Denise Ferreira da Silva.

The technopolitical infrastructure *activism* in contemporary art has to do with the organization of social relations and interactions: the ways people and things come together, afforded and mediated by art. These social relations can be found around and before the production of art, sourcing contributions from not only the artist herself, but also all the other efforts that are organized by the infrastructurally aided mode of production for artworks. Artworks have agency by giving voice to socially undergirded experiences that have not as yet been given adequate expression. Art, in this perspective, is an infrastructure for political expression. Moreover, art, when considered as an effective implementation of an infrastructure, can be seen to organize the social relations and exchanges that play out in the use of artworks. Hence, the work of art is an infrastructure for gathering, for collective deliberation, and eventually for negotiating the appropriateness of what is presented as art.

Finally, the question of infrastructure politics can open a set of new dialogical relations between academic research in the arts and art practices. Which affordances does the infrastructural analysis and the vocabulary of infrastructure aesthetics offer to a broader field of cultural workers and cultural institutions? What kind of feedback loops do the scholarly endeavors spill into the very infrastructures of artistic production, presentation, and distribution?

The new academic sensibility of onto-epistemological and mediated co(re)production in the infrastructures of art also reintroduces the role of cultural studies in relation to cultural policy; being able to describe, analyze, and interpret the interrelatedness of art and its supporting or hindering surroundings, the cultural analyst can pose questions such as, which artistic practices can profit from the cultural policies in a given national frame? Which kinds of authorship are supported and created in social media platforms? Which notions of quality are giving access to higher artistic education? Which curatorial concepts have coproduced an exhibition? Which artists' lives are possible within a given relation between arts councils, private foundations, and unemployment subsidies? What kind of readerships and authorships are constituted across racial profiling in reviews and publishing houses?

Controversies about art and cultural politics – about quality, accessibility, artistic freedom, separatist practices, and critique of normativity in organizations – confront the historical scales upon which we judge artistic quality, making the common value of art to society a much more contested question today than it was only decades ago (Ahmed 2007; 2012; Daugaard 2018b; Schmidt 2019; 2022). Migration, decolonializing attempts, and digital communities, amongst others, have complicated existing national identities as homogenous entities to which art and culture cater in unison. Demographical, technological, and onto-epistemological changes require a reconceptualization of the social and political import of cultural infrastructures of art for the reproduction of democratic culture as “we” know it. Who is addressed in notions of national communities? Who is represented in the art institutions and who or what chooses, who is being chosen?

The following chapters are divided into three parts that reflect different levels of engagement with infrastructure in cultural studies. The first part samples a selection of recent artworks in an attempt to develop an analytical amenability to understand and assess the modes of appearance and significance of artworks that use and reflect infrastructure in their expression. The second part engages with the question of whether the recent focus on infrastructure in the arts and beyond can help reformulate and further develop the aesthetic categories with which we analyze aesthetic and cultural expressions; and whether these categories might also be able to shed new light on traditional questions and topics in aesthetic theory. Finally, the third part asks how infrastructural art practices and the new ways of understanding infrastructure aesthetics can further contribute to describe and better understand the political dimensions hovering around art and cultural practices, ranging from the political import of the infrastructures at work in the art world to the ways in which aesthetic infrastructures interface with and operate exchanges with the larger societal infrastructures in which they are embedded.

Part one – Art: Inversion, invention, intervention

The first part offers analytical methodologies for describing and interpreting artistic practices that foreground the backgrounds of art worlds: artistic practices that actively invert and intervene in logics and logistics, in immaterial and material infrastructures, both in the making, the presentation, and the circulation and maintenance of artworks. Many of the artistic practices analyzed call out the power structures of inequality in the European art world based on gender, coloniality, extractivism, or Eurocentrism. In artistically intervening ways of participating in the world “outside the arts,” negotiating who has accessibility, attention, and influence, the chapters offer – in distinct ways – a new understanding of art as action in the world, as reparative world-making, art as co(re)producer of what is livable, for artists and cultural workers in the arts, and also for people outside the arts, and not merely as an invitation for reflection or as a representation of the world. The authors of this part trace how artistic practices of infrastructural inversion and intervention can turn our attention to social, economic, and material structures designed to evade them, and in turn, invent more sustainable and agentially distributed infrastructures for social art worlds. Thus, the chapters dwell on artistic practices (often by collectives, sometimes anonymous) of infrastructural acts and offer methodologies to carve out historical habits of producing and examining art – ways of authorizing, selecting, judging quality, financing, valorizing, and storing – that question the onto-epistemological grounds of the Western art worlds as we know them and whether they can remain the grounds on which common futures can be crafted.

The section opens with three chapters on collective organization in politically tense and socially volatile periods: in the 1930s, in the 1970s, and in our historical present. With a historical example of *infrastructural inversion* located in the feminist separatist avantgarde of the 1970s, art historian Line Ellegaard shows how gendered infrastructures in art history were inverted in a collective artistic project on intergenerational solidarity between women artists in Copenhagen in 1975. Through an artistic archiving of experiences of women artists +40, presented at the 1975 *Women’s Exhibition* in Copenhagen, it emerged how infrastructures of access, selection, and (in)attention were gendered through the idea of “greatness” and “artistic quality,” as well as biased critique and underrepresentation of women artists. Ellegaard stresses how the inversion of gendered infrastructural inattention also made it possible for women to find solidarity in difference: contradictory affective attachments and diverse ways of negotiating lived experiences of inequality.

Where Ellegaard’s reading of an infrastructural inversion in the 1970s brings out gendered and class-based inequalities, exposed in a solidary and intergenera-

tional group exhibition by and with Danish women artists, performance theorist Cecilie Ullerup Schmidt looks at the Indonesian artist collective *ruangrupa*'s recent attempt to decenter Eurocentric aesthetics and install a way of sharing and being together and redistributing means and attention through a collective *infrastructuring* at documenta fifteen in Kassel, Germany. Schmidt analyzes how artist collectives from the Global South encounter the material and immaterial *Engpässe* (chokepoints) of Eurocentric aesthetics, including the financial and logistic need for flexible solo artists, a recognizable, transparent, and delimited notion of the artwork and its invitation to consume or participate, and an authorized intentionality rooted in one identifiable and responsible curator. Schmidt suggests that the artist collectives in their exhibited practices and in their (im)possibility of navigating art critique and the German press, invert colonial separability and demarcating lines at the heart of the modernist, Eurocentric notion of art as we (still) encounter it at documenta.

With a historicizing focus beyond the otherwise much-represented central- and North-European axis in this book, literary scholar Emma Sofie Brogaard investigates The Black Women's International collective practices across the Soviet Union and USA in the 1930s. Analyzing mixed practices such as the 1935 black-and-white, silent biopic *Tajihon Shadieva* directed by Liudmila Snezhinskaia, Louise Thompson's reportage from "The National Negro Congress" held in Chicago in 1936, and the never produced 1932 feature-length fiction film *Black and White* by the German-Russian studio Mezhrabpomfilm, Brogaard summons aesthetic infrastructures shaping a black left feminist sensibility: aesthetic infrastructures visually and socially connecting, supporting, and "holding" black women workers intersectionally and across continents and archives. By evoking relations between the three practices and across archives, Brogaard intervenes in the historiography of art history through connecting and cutting in the archival infrastructures of black left feminism.

The next three chapters reread historical objects from art and media history through an infrastructural analysis. Through analyses of historical statues, VHS tapes, and public service television, we as audiences and scholars increase our awareness of bias and interests layered in the production, circulation, and maintenance of cultural products. Art historian Mathias Danbolt and archeologist Amalie Skovmøller thus suggest, in a context of statue toppling since Rhodes Must Fall in South Africa and Black Lives Matter protests worldwide, an infrastructural analytics for the becoming of sculptural monuments. Their "Monument as Relation Model" offers a new understanding of monuments as conditioned on relations – processes behind, around, and in front of monuments' visual appearance – rather than as singular, stationary aesthetic objects. The model proposes six steps in the becoming and authorization of monuments: *authorization, financialization, manufacturing,*

mediation, ritual, and maintenance. These six steps involve funding streams, networks of agents, and a continuation of performances of maintenance, and thus show how monuments are not just a matter of someone portrayed on a plinth, a visual shape, and grandeur encountered, but much more a monumentality constructed and upheld infrastructurally: over time, and by a network of many people, intentions, and resources. The model is analytically built on the French sculptor Jacques-François-Joseph Saly's equestrian statue of Frederik V in Copenhagen from the second half of the eighteenth century and attunes to a sensibility toward both the material and cultural impact in the era of Danish colonialism yet performed and upheld ever after. However, being a toolbox with six analytical entry points, Skovmøller and Danbolt's model can be applied to analyze (and intervene in) infrastructures of monumentality across men on horses on plinths, buildings, busts, and digital images, as well as across historical periods.

Importing and examining materialities of "old-school" media and their infrastructures embedded in another historical period is a strategy in the two final contributions of the section, both written from inside artistic research projects. Eva la Cour embarks on the live editing technique of television making. Kristoffer Gansing and Linda Hilfling Ritasdatter collect and edit VHS tapes as they are establishing a speculative video store. Artist researcher Eva la Cour analyzes the potential of working infrastructurally with *live editing* as a shared mode of epistemological production among people involved in experimental film production. With her artist colleague Mia Edelgart, la Cour has looked into the practices and relations of Belgian producer, editor, and scriptwriter Jef Cornelis – a figure who used public service broadcasting as a scene for experimentation in the 1970s and 1980s. Cornelis not only inverted TV infrastructures and experimented within TV as a medium but also explored art as infrastructure in itself as a central element of public service. The chapter offers insights into la Cour and Edelgart's own recent iteration of Cornelis' legacy with experimentation and live editing in an encounter with collaborators of Cornelis, and a theoretical reflection on both artistic practice as epistemic disobedience and live editing as an infrastructural image practice.

Like Skovmøller and Danbolt and la Cour, artist researcher Linda Hilfling Ritasdatter and media theorist and curator Kristoffer Gansing also take a comparativist approach, scrutinizing historical media infrastructures in order to better understand contemporary media infrastructures and their inherent (dis)continuities. Insisting on the interdependent relation in infrastructures between medium and mentality, between material and immaterial, between the technical and the cultural, between effect and affect, Ritasdatter and Gansing critique and propose alternative modes of organization in the context of a current paradigm of cloud-based computing. Informed by intersectional and trans*feminist approaches to

computation and world-making as well as philosophies of degrowth, they describe their artistic material intervention *A Video Store After the End of the World*, which re-enacts the VHS medium vis-à-vis the streaming economy, and offer a speculation on the relation between material (self-)limitation and imagined limitlessness. Their chapter undertakes a double infrastructural inversion: by inverting old and spatiotemporally limited media infrastructures (VHS tapes), the promise of current media infrastructures – the digital, cloud-based endless streaming – is likewise inverted. The double inversion allows Ritasdatter and Gansing to identify dis/continuities across old and new media infrastructures: practices of indexing, categorization, and order on shelves, the dependency on asymmetric and often hidden labor of maintaining and caring for media infrastructures, the concept of the limitless and the desire of endless growth, as well as the misunderstanding that intangible media equals no resources. The remembering and comparativist speculation between old and current media infrastructures allow Ritasdatter and Gansing to raise questions about continuities of extractive ways of producing, consuming, and sharing – and to demand other (collective) ways of imagining and inventing degrowth, de-, and recycling in future media materiality.

Part two – Aesthetics: Organization, mediation, relation

The five chapters in the second part engage with the potentials of infrastructure as a properly aesthetic concept. If the infrastructural turn in the humanities and social sciences that has taken place over the last decades has contributed to reorient a number of disciplines and provide not only new conceptual tools but also new interpretive frameworks and perspectives, the aim of this part of the book is to gauge how concepts, epistemologies, and research questions developed in the wide and interdisciplinary field of infrastructure studies can be accommodated in the aesthetic disciplines and eventually contribute not only to better understand and relate to infrastructural tendencies in the arts but also develop and add to the theoretical state of the art in aesthetic research. The keywords heading this part: organization, mediation, and relation highlight features that are seminal to infrastructure studies and at the same time resonate importantly with aesthetics. Organization, or functional distribution, is a critical feature on different scales in the art world, from the distribution of tasks between different agents in the field to the institutional organization of hierarchies and dependencies, and from the internal coherence of artistic articulations to the approbated modes of relating to them. Me-

diation is a concept that has probably a stronger foothold in aesthetics than in technical contexts, but it has become increasingly important in infrastructure studies at large to be attentive to the many and diverse forms of mediation that are played out in infrastructural contexts. At the same time, the infrastructural use of mediation has in turn vivified the, at times, somewhat dormant knowledge and understanding of mediation that itself holds an undisputed central place in art studies of every kind. Relations, finally, not only quintessentially conjure up what infrastructure is all about – connecting what is to be connected and disconnecting what should not be connected; they also epitomize everything important in aesthetics, from the compositional connection of expressive elements in an artwork to the connectedness of the artist; from the connections brought about when relating to an artwork to the connections one is introduced to by way of engaging with art.

Cultural studies scholar Frida Sandström's chapter, "A Crisis of Autonomy. Critique of Art and Sexuality in 1974," is a case study that addresses one of the most sacrosanct ideas in modern aesthetic theory: that of the autonomy of art, as precisely an infrastructural feature that contributes to regulate the order and function of the art field. The crisis of autonomy evoked in the chapter title is inscribed in a bigger picture of the crisis of capitalist accumulation in the early 1970s, the crisis that marked the transition from the so-called glorious thirty years of growing economies after the Second World War to the long recession that followed. This crisis deeply impacted the infrastructure of the art world not least by way of the transformation of the bourgeois public sphere through commercialization and new waves of popular culture, and with it – particularly important in Sandström's chapter – the traditional expert art critic. The crisis is exemplarily evoked with a stunt by Lynda Bengalis who placed an advertisement with a kitschy, pornographic image of herself in the high-brow journal *Artforum*. In Sandström's multifaceted reading of the stunt, the combination of mercantile intent (buying advertisement space), "cheap" pornographic imagery, and a nonetheless provocative posture (Bengalis is posing with a clip-on phallus) juxtaposes art, capital, and sexuality so as to expose otherwise hidden aspects of the infrastructural organization of the art world.

The two following chapters depart from extant and highly important infrastructures in our present. Media studies scholar Daniel Irrgang's chapter discusses the techno-scientific infrastructure dedicated to map and monitor climate change and environmental deterioration, while scholar in art and digital culture Tanya Ravn Ag starts out from the explosive growth of networked digital infrastructures and the ensuing proliferations of new interfaces between machinic processes and human bodies. The particular aesthetic question that animates both chapters concerns the possibilities and strategies for *representing* these new infrastructural realities in an aesthetic mediation.